The New Zealand experience was best summed up by the home captain Stephen Fleming. At the end of the tour Fleming stated that the tour had done enough to breed a sense of false complacency among the bowlers, while the batsmen were now worrying about flaws in technique that weren't really there. The conditions were simply not good enough for international cricket and the series was not the best advertisement for the game.

Warming up

There was no doubt I was not in the best physical shape when the team left for the World Cup in South Africa and Zimbabwe in February 2003. I was recovering from three injuries: the finger, the ankle and a strained hamstring. As a result, at our training camp in Paarl, in the Western Cape, I was not able to run with the team and spent my time cycling to keep up my cardio exercises. It was frustrating, but I knew I had to push myself to get back to fitness before the first match of the tournament against the Netherlands on 12 February.

The injury that bothered me most was the ankle. It had not fully healed and I had to strap it before every practice session and match. Strapping the ankle all the time became an ordeal and it started to frustrate me. So much so that one day I was careless when removing the strapping after training and suddenly felt a strange sensation in my hand. I was holding the strapping, which had a thick layer of my skin on it, which had come out of my heel. The skin was stuck to the tape and I ended up putting it back because otherwise there would have to be a hole in a sensitive area of the foot. I know it sounds gruesome, but there was little else I could do in the circumstances. After that it was particularly painful when I had to go into the sea with the rest of the team as part of our recovery routine and the salty water would really sting. The incident at least taught me to be more careful about handling my injuries, however frustrating they might be.

We played two practice games, both against the KwaZulu-Natal side. While we batted reasonably in the first game on 4 February in Pietermaritzburg, with Yuvi and Dravid both doing well, the game on 6 February at Chatsworth didn't go according to plan. We managed to get the opposition out fairly cheaply, and I remember Sourav saying that, because we needed as much batting practice as possible, the opposition